Brussels would be flexible on euro and Schengen if UK tried to rejoin

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Brussels would be flexible on euro and Schengen if UK tried to rejoin
By Jon Stone · Oct 30, 2026, 6:25 PM · View in your browser

LONDON — Brussels would be flexible on letting Britain stay out of the euro or the Schengen area if the U.K. applied to rejoin the European Union, two EU officials familiar with the bloc's approach have told POLITICO.

Britain would not necessarily have to join the single currency or passport-free zone — a concern held by some British voters — according to the two officials, who were granted anonymity to speak freely about a sensitive matter.

Opening the door for the U.K. to return to the bloc on similar terms would be a serious boost to the prospects of restoring the country's EU membership, and a rejection of those who have argued Britain shouldn't be allowed to return under its previous terms.

U.K. Prime Minister Andy Burnham has said Brexit isn't working — and even suggested rejoining the EU could make it into Labour's next election manifesto.

But some euroskeptics say a returning Britain would likely be strong-armed into making commitments to European integration that go beyond the membership deal it had before Brexit.

Polling conducted by YouGov earlier this month found that 55 percent of Brits want to reverse Brexit, with just 34 percent wanting to remain outside the EU, but the numbers shift significantly if joining the euro single currency and Schengen passport-free area become requirements — with just 35 percent in favor to 43 percent opposed.

EU officials stress that the union currently has no formal stance on Britain joining as London has not yet applied.

But they say the EU always takes the specific circumstances of a country into account when conducting negotiating talks. "In theory there is a standard approach but in practice you see that it is more flexible," one of the officials told POLITICO. "There are different models."

The clarification could be a boost for Burnham's ambition to see Britain back in the EU in his lifetime.

The European Commission did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

'More harm than good'

When it was an EU member, the U.K. had exemptions from Schengen and the euro — built on a series of opt-outs and agreements negotiated over decades of membership.

But states who have joined the union more recently have made commitments to move towards both goals.

While Burnham has said he wants to eventually see the U.K. rejoin, he says he will be led by U.K. public opinion on the matter.

Crucially, he has said nothing will happen before the next general election when he seeks a fresh mandate at the polls. That is due no later than July 2029.

On Nov. 20 Burnham will meet with European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen in Brussels to sign off a package of measures meant to smooth the post-Brexit relationship.

These negotiations, begun under Burnham's predecessor Keir Starmer, include an agreement to smooth food trade, new visas for young people, and a linking of emissions trading systems.

But the prime minister has also said he will use the occasion of the summit to set out options for an even bigger overhaul of Brexit, which he said "has caused more harm than good."

Burnham has said the options could include membership of the single market or customs union, but also rejoining wholesale.

The chosen option is expected to make it into Labour's next election manifesto, with the next contest due in 2029 but latitude given to the prime minister to call an earlier poll.

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